A Sci-Fi Novel Wins the Booker Prize for the First Time

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For the first time ever, a science fiction novel has won the Booker Prize. M. John Harrison's The End of Everything took the 2026 prize, one of the most **prestigious** awards for fiction written in English and published in the United Kingdom or Ireland. It is the **capstone** of a 60-year career. Harrison published his first short story in 1966, and he is widely considered one of the most original voices in British fantasy and science fiction. He also worked as an editor, reviewer, and critic for New Worlds, a magazine that helped launch the 'New Wave' of science fiction in Britain in the 1970s.

The winning book is a **post-apocalyptic** novel, set on the south coast of England. It is as much about an alien catastrophe as it is about people's efforts to ignore it. The hero, Philip Tennent, has moved to the small town of Dalston-on-Sea from London, after the capital was taken over by strange, short-lived beings called the iGhetti. Nobody knows if they are really aliens at all. Tennent scrapes by collecting alien artifacts from the beach and selling them. Then something stranger than usual shows up: a baby-like **hybrid** that keeps growing and learning. Tennent and his aunt Marnie just want to get rid of it, while a strange apocalypse unfolds around them. Harrison described the book as a portrayal of 'the failure of explanation in society.' He even said it was something 'that might have been submitted for **serialisation** in New Worlds in 1967.' Harrison has won many awards before, including both the Arthur C. Clarke Award and the Philip K. Dick Award in 2007 for his novel Nova Swing. He has also written far beyond science fiction, including the mountain-climbing novel Climbers and the urban fantasy The Course of the Heart.

Word Treasure

prestigious -- Highly respected and admired by many people.
post-apocalyptic -- Set in a world after a disaster that has destroyed much of civilisation.
capstone -- The crowning achievement at the top of a long career.
hybrid -- Something made from a mix of two different things.
serialisation -- Publishing a story in parts, one after another, in a magazine.

Background you need

The Booker Prize is one of the most famous awards for novels written in English and published in the United Kingdom or Ireland.

Science fiction tells stories about imagined futures, new technology and strange worlds, and it had never won the prize before.

M. John Harrison has been writing for 60 years, starting with a short story in 1966, and he worked for New Worlds, a magazine that helped launch a new wave of science fiction in Britain.

His winning book is set on the south coast of England, where people are trying to carry on while a strange disaster unfolds around them.

Break it down

LEAD: A science fiction novel has won the Booker Prize for the first time ever.

KEY EVENT: M. John Harrison's The End of Everything takes the 2026 prize

+- WHO: M. John Harrison, a writer at the end of a 60-year career.

+- WHAT: The Booker Prize, one of the most prestigious awards for fiction written in English and published in the United Kingdom or Ireland.

+- WHY IT STANDS OUT: Harrison is widely considered one of the most original voices in British fantasy and science fiction.

THE BOOK: A post-apocalyptic novel set on the south coast of England, about an alien catastrophe and people's efforts to ignore it.

+- HERO: Philip Tennent, who moved to Dalston-on-Sea from London and scrapes by selling alien artifacts from the beach.

+- TURN: A baby-like hybrid that keeps growing and learning shows up, and Tennent and his aunt Marnie want to get rid of it.

EVIDENCE: Harrison called the book a portrayal of 'the failure of explanation in society' and said it might have been submitted for serialisation in New Worlds in 1967.

OPEN QUESTION: Nobody knows if the iGhetti are really aliens at all.

Why it matters

Prizes shape what kinds of stories get noticed: a science fiction win shows that books about imagined worlds can stand beside any other great novel, and it may bring new readers to a genre they had never tried.

Test what you remember

1. What is special about The End of Everything winning the Booker Prize?

- (A) It is the longest novel to win it
- (B) It is the first science fiction novel to win it
- (C) It is the first children's book to win it
- (D) It is the first book by a woman to win it

2. Who wrote The End of Everything?

- (A) Philip K. Dick
- (B) Philip Tennent
- (C) M. John Harrison
- (D) Arthur C. Clarke

3. Where is the winning book set?

- (A) On the south coast of England
- (B) In New York
- (C) In Scotland
- (D) In London

4. What are the strange beings that took over London called?

- (A) The Dalstons
- (B) The Hybrids
- (C) The New Wave
- (D) The iGhetti

5. How does Philip Tennent make a living?

- (A) By collecting alien artifacts from the beach and selling them
- (B) By writing books about aliens
- (C) By working in a London shop
- (D) By teaching at a school

6. Which awards did Harrison win in 2007 for Nova Swing?

- (A) The Costa Award and the Women's Prize
- (B) The Arthur C. Clarke Award and the Philip K. Dick Award
- (C) The Booker Prize and the Nobel Prize
- (D) Two Hugo Awards

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: A 4: D 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. M. John Harrison: He described the book as a portrayal of 'the failure of explanation in society.'

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):